

Fogazzaro's Little World of the Past : Program Notes for an Italian "Classic"

P. M. PASINETTI

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The Politics of Italian Foreign Policy [Robert Wohl]; *La Posilecheata* [C.S.]; *Everyone's Hour* [Franco Ferrucci]; *A Family portrait - The Job of Writing* [G.P.B.].

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The Oxford Library of Italian Classics is conducted along canonical Italian lines; the selections are generally made within the area that would be familiar to the average Italian bourgeois, vaguely respectful of "national masterpieces" he never reads. Fogazzaro's *Piccolo mondo antico* ("The Little World of the Past," translated by W. J. Strachan, 1962) is not, as far as I know, on compulsory reading lists of secondary schools but certainly holds its own in textbooks and in the vague national conscience. It is still often accompanied by that tag, "the best Italian novel after Manzoni," which implies more or less overtly the notion that Fogazzaro is a writer in the Manzoni manner.

Actually, although both writers use narrative voices that are by and large traceable to the cultivated middle-class, Manzoni's style is so much more varied and subtle than Fogazzaro's, that the latter looks definitely shabby by comparison. Manzoni's celebrated humor, in the picturing of characters but not in any direct aping of their presumed speech, by contrast makes Fogazzaro's vernacular dialogue sound heavily provincial. True, both writers see their respective world from religious angles; but whereas Manzoni's humble hero and heroine have their destinies regulated by a Divine Providence about which they are hardly articulate, Fogazzaro's protagonists are middle-class or provincial nobility, making a great deal of their religious beliefs and disbeliefs, ambiguous and confused as these may be. In fact, the choice of focus possibly constitutes the deepest difference between Manzo-